

The Inspection Playbook

Staffbook

Free to keep, copy and share

The staff side of an Ofsted inspection, in plain English.

An inspection is not a mystery. On the staff side, inspectors ask for the same things almost every time, and every one of them can be ready before anyone knocks on the door.

This playbook goes through the eleven things they open with. For each one: what they ask, what good looks like, what fails, and what to fix this week. Then the two scripts most homes never have, word for word. Then how to run your own mock inspection in an hour.

It pairs with the free workbook, which does the tracking for you: the training matrix that colours its own expiries, the supervision tracker, the DBS re-check log, the diploma clocks and the governance clocks.

Nothing here is legal advice. It is the working knowledge of people who run homes, written down.

The eleven things, one by one

1. Statement of purpose

The first document of every inspection. It describes what your home is for and how it is staffed.

Good looks like: reviewed in the last year, matches how the home actually runs, staffing section is current.

What fails:

written three managers ago. Says things the home no longer does.

Fix this week: read it end to end. Mark every sentence that is no longer true. That is your revision list.

2. Staff list with qualifications

Who works here, what they hold, and what they are working towards.

Good looks like: one page, current, includes the Level 3 diploma clocks for anyone still inside their two years.

What fails:

a payroll export with no qualifications on it.

Fix this week: fill in the Diploma clocks tab in the workbook. Anyone red needs a plan today.

3. Recruitment and vetting records

The full Schedule 2 file for every person: identity, DBS, references, history, qualifications.

Good looks like: every file complete, and you know it is complete because someone checked against a list.

What fails:

one unexplained gap in one work history. It is the fastest finding available to an inspector.

Fix this week: run the Staff file checklist tab against your longest-serving person. Then the newest.

4. Training records

Mandatory courses in date for everyone, with the expiry dates known, not guessed.

Good looks like: a matrix where the expiries are computed and someone looks every Monday.

What fails:

dates in someone's head. A first aid certificate that quietly ran out in March.

Fix this week: move your dates into the Training matrix tab. Fix the first red cell on the Expiries tab.

5. Supervision records

Regular, effective, recorded. Including the manager's own supervision, which is the record most often missing.

Good looks like: on the cycle your statement of purpose promises, showing real conversations with agreed actions.

What fails:

gaps in the cycle. Records that are a date and two signatures. No record for the manager.

Fix this week: fill the Supervision tracker tab. If the manager's row is red, fix that one first.

6. Staffing rotas

The rota as planned, and evidence of what actually happened when reality diverged.

Good looks like: published rotas, corrected when swaps happen, with cover levels and a first aider on every shift.

What fails:

a rota that says one thing while everyone knows the month went differently.

Fix this week: check last month's rota against what really happened. Correct it. That correction is the record.

7. Allegations records

Held securely, with the timescales evidenced: reported to a senior manager immediately, the designated officer told within one working day.

Good looks like: a locked record showing dates for every step, however uncomfortable the content.

What fails:

an allegation everyone remembers but nobody wrote down at the time.

Fix this week: check the last allegation record shows its dates. If there has never been one, check the team knows the reporting steps cold.

8. Regulation 44 reports

The independent visitor, every month, and what happened to the actions they raised.

Good looks like: a full run of months, each report filed, each action closed and traceable.

What fails:

a missing month. Actions raised in March still open in August with no note why.

Fix this week: fill the visit grid on the Governance clocks tab. A missed month is a breach; know before they do.

9. Regulation 45 review

Your own six-month review of the quality of care, sent to Ofsted within 28 days of completion.

Good looks like: built from the home's own records, honest about weaknesses, with actions that then actually happened.

What fails:

overdue, or glowing in a way your own records contradict.

Fix this week: find the date of your last one. Add six months. Put the deadline in the diary.

10. Notifications

The serious events you told Ofsted about, within 24 hours, with who else was told and what was done.

Good looks like: a log that matches reality: every notifiable event, notified, with the follow-up recorded.

What fails:

an event in the daily logs that never became a notification.

Fix this week: agree with your team, in one sentence each, what counts as notifiable. Ambiguity is where these get missed.

11. Location assessment

The annual review of whether the home's location keeps children safe.

Good looks like: reviewed within the year, involving the local police and authority view, with the risks named and managed.

What fails:

three years old, or missing the thing everyone locally knows about.

Fix this week: check the date on yours. Put its renewal on the Governance clocks tab.

Script one: the employment gap conversation

You have found a hole in someone's work history. Here is the whole conversation. It takes two minutes and it is not an accusation.

"While I was tidying the files I noticed a gap in your work history, between [month] and [month]. It is completely normal, I just need one line in writing about what that period was. Travelling, family, between jobs, anything. What was it?"

Then write exactly what they say, date it, and put it in the file. Done. If they cannot remember precisely, "believed to be between roles" dated today is still a written explanation.

The rule: written down is a pass, silence is a finding. Never leave the conversation without the sentence.

Script two: the reference verification call

A written reference is a claim. This call makes it evidence. Ring the organisation's main number, not the mobile on the letter, and ask for the person who signed it.

"Hello, I'm [name], manager at a children's home. [Person] has applied to work with us and gave us a reference in your name. Can I take two minutes to confirm it? Did you write it? Can you confirm the dates they worked with you, and their role? Why did they leave? And the one I have to ask: would you employ them again, in work around children?"

Then two lines on paper: who you spoke to, when, and what they confirmed. Date it, initial it, staple it to the reference. That note is what inspectors look for.

If the referee hesitates on the last question, that hesitation is the most useful thing the call could have given you. Follow it.

Run your own mock inspection in an hour

Book one uninterrupted hour. Bring the self-audit sheet from the pack and pretend to be the inspector, which mostly means being politely relentless about evidence.

First ten minutes: the eleven items. For each one, actually fetch the thing. Not "we have that" but the document, on the table. Grade it Ready, Question or Gap while it is in your hand.

Next twenty minutes: two staff files, chosen the way inspectors choose. Your longest-serving person and your newest starter. Run the Schedule 2 checklist against both. The long-server tests your history; the starter tests your process.

Next twenty minutes: follow one thread all the way down. Pick last month's regulation 44 report, take one action from it, and trace it: who owned it, when it closed, where the evidence lives. Inspectors pull threads; a thread that snaps in your hand snaps in theirs.

Last ten minutes: write the list. Every Gap gets a name and a date. Every Question gets a sentence about what would make it Ready. Put the list where the team sees it.

Do this once a quarter and a real inspection stops being an event. It becomes a Tuesday where you already know every answer.

The new law, in plain English

The Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act became law in April 2026. The headlines were about capping profits. The practical changes for a home's paperwork are quieter and worth knowing.

There is more financial oversight, especially of larger providers. There is more attention on provider groups as a whole, not just single homes. And there is a clear direction of travel: be able to show where the money goes and how the home is run, because the asking is going to increase.

For staff records this means three things. Workforce numbers, turnover and agency use, are becoming things people look at rather than vibes. Spending on quality and safety is the spending that always survives scrutiny. And records that can be produced quickly and completely are becoming the mark of a well-run home.

None of this is frightening for a home whose files are straight. All of it is a reason to straighten them this quarter rather than next.

The pack, and one honest line

The workbook next to this playbook holds nine working tools: the training matrix and its automatic expiries, the supervision tracker, the DBS re-check log, the diploma clocks, the governance clocks with the visit grid, the Schedule 2 file checklist, the employment gap worksheet, and the self-audit.

Everything is free because every home needs this and most homes are too busy to build it. It was put together with a serving Responsible Individual with twenty years in children's homes. Use it, copy it, hand it to the home down the road.

That is the whole page. Good luck with the files, and better than luck: a quiet Monday habit.